overruled by London).[45] Nationalists also feared the threat to Afghanistan's independence – until now Anglo-Russian rivalry had prevented the country being absorbed entirely by either power. By laying to rest this competition, the road lay open to greater encroachment upon Afghan freedom.[46] In Persia too, the effects of the convention would be very negative for Britain. Prior to 1907, British officials were generally held in high regard by the Persian people, particularly in the early years of the Persian revolution, when they sided with the reformers against the shah.[47] Indeed, the Persian constitutionalists looked to Britain for inspiration on how to form a democratic system of government while retaining a monarchy.

For Russia, its relationship with the shah was crucial in helping to retain its influence in the north of Persia.[48] This, together with its own domestic political issues, meant that Russia took a natural aversion to the reformers, and made efforts to ensure the shah remained on his throne.[49] That Russia was willing to use force in order to achieve its ends compounded the hostility that the Persian public felt towards its northern neighbour. The Cossack Division,[50] for example, would often be deployed during the revolution in order to quell popular unrest, such as in June 1908 when it occupied Tehran following violent protests by the public against the shah.[51]

From Russia's point of view, it appeared that Persia was gradually sinking into an unacceptable state of disarray – something unwanted so close to its own borders.[52] As one Russian contemporary observed, 'it always happens that the more civilized State is forced, in the interest of security of its frontier and its commercial relations, to exercise a certain ascendancy over those whom their turbulent and unsettled character makes most undesirable neighbours'.[53] Yet, Russian heavy-handedness in trying to secure northern Persia from descending into anarchy ensured the enduring hostility of the Persian people. Britain, meanwhile, although claiming to be non-interventionist, inclined towards a form of constitutional monarchy for Persia. Naturally sympathising with the cause of the reformers, the British also depended for their commercial prosperity in the south of Persia on the anti-shah tribes.[54] In July 1905, when some 12,000 political refugees sought bast (sanctuary) within the British legation in Tehran, not only did the British consul general happily accommodate them, but he even recognised 'many friends and acquaintances' among the Persians, whom he